

COVER STORY

SHELL OF ITS FORMER GLORY

The now-crumbling Latino Learning Center in East Houston is seeking \$7 million for renovations after a promised federal grant stalled.

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THE LIST

In need of extra funds? Here are the top commercial lenders.

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Energy giant lays off 174 employees

Baker Hughes announces the 'mass layoff' but does not say why the plant is closing.

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COVER STORY

HISTORY IN NEED

The Latino Learning Center once hosted Martin Luther King Jr. and first lady Barbara Bush.

Now it's falling apart waiting on funds once promised.

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*Rodolfo González,
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Latino Learning Center*



A Latino nonprofit in Houston is making slow progress toward a much-needed \$7 million renovation of a historic 1910s building that was a victim of federal and state politics.

The Latino Learning Center, located in East Downtown between the Second and Fifth wards, has been working within the community for 46 years, providing education and vocational training along with operating senior housing in Eastwood and South Houston. However, classes have been pushed to a standstill in the past two to three years as the organization fights to keep itself afloat in the center's dilapidated state.

"Our board responds to the needs of the community. We've been doing that for 46 years," said co-founder John Alemán, a military veteran who co-founded the center with another veteran friend but is now the only living founder. "We had about 60 (classes) a year, but we've been doing that for about over 45 years, so I haven't done the math – but that's a lot (of people)."

The project to create the center itself took the founders three years. They transformed the 50,000-square-foot abandoned building at 3522 Polk St. from a shell filled with undergrowth to a vibrant hub that in its heyday welcomed key figures such as Martin Luther King Jr. and first lady Barbara Bush. It also became the first home to Houston's Hispanic Chamber of Commerce and LULAC (League of United Latin American Citizens) at one point in time.

During the Houston Business Journal's tour of the facility, it was difficult to reconcile the center's significance as a longstanding pillar of its community with its poor physical condition currently. The ceiling has gaping holes and water stains, and HVAC and electrical classrooms are empty and falling apart. Its events hall – where it hosted its graduations and a visit from first lady Bush – has seen better days.

The center has big plans for a complete modernization that would allow it to restart classes. Houston-based architecture firm Collaborate Architects has led the design work.

"(The renovation) brings it up to a more modern space. Of course, it gives us more classroom space for more programs, which we'd like to add," said Mike Moreno, director of special programs.

Some of the current classrooms are so damaged, they weren't being used because of their condition, he noted.

There are also plans to open up part

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of the second floor and add a courtyard with views of the downtown area in the background.

However, the only thing standing in the way is money.

Left in limbo

The center was expecting a nearly \$2 million federal grant promised by the late U.S. Rep. Sheila Jackson Lee, who represented the 18th Congressional District, where the center is located. However, that all came to a halt when she died in July 2024. Former Mayor Sylvester Turner, who succeeded Jackson Lee, took up the cause, but he died suddenly in March 2025.

The center – like all of the 18th Congressional District’s residents – became disenfranchised after Turner’s death. Gov. Greg Abbott set the special election for Turner’s successor in November 2025, eight months after his death, despite election law requiring him to call an election as soon as possible. Abbott cited previous administrative failures in Harris County, arguing the county needed extra time to organize an election.

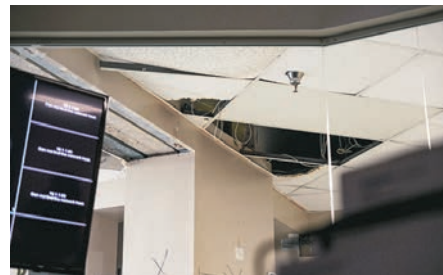
Between the lack of representation in Congress and then the 43-day federal government shutdown, the grant, which was to come from the U.S. Department of Housing and Urban Development, did not make it into the federal budget.

In the meantime, the center has worked with what it has, including a \$1.5 million grant it received from the city of Houston under Turner’s administration for a new roof and an air-conditioning system. The center also recently repaired its elevator, which had been out of service for close to nine years.

“It was the last four or five months of Mayor Turner’s term,” Rodolfo González, the center’s president and CEO, said in Spanish. “He told us to apply for a grant to see what could be done. That grant has been used to replace 30,000 square feet of roof and buy 14 A/C units that have all been bought new.”

The center also is using some of those funds to replace the electric grid and elevator. However, González simply said what’s obvious in the appearance of the center: “We need more.”

There’s hope that some work can be completed. González has started to ask for bids on a limited demolition for an interior renovation of the first floor using leftover money from the city’s grant. The work will include renova-



tion of the classrooms, event hall and circulation spaces.

If it proceeds, the renovation likely would start in the fall and cost approximately \$750,000, according to the Texas Department of Licensing and Regulation. In addition, the center is drafting plans to make up the approximately \$5 million capital campaign goal it has to reconstruct the ailing center, González told the HBJ.

Meanwhile, the group is trying to make inroads where it can, first talking to Congressman Al Green, who ran for the newly redrawn 18th Congressional District that scraped a good chunk of Green’s voters out of his 9th Congressional District. However, he lost the Democratic primary runoff in May against Christian Menefee. Now, they’re attempting to petition Menefee.

Back to the start

In many ways, the center has come full circle, with a building in a dismal state and with voices that have at best been ignored or at worst tacitly silenced by neglect. The shell of a building was a gift from the city, but by all accounts, there wasn’t much there to give.

“The very first time that anyone wanted to do something here in the community was the day that Frank Orosco and myself were on that caddy corner looking over here at the rundown building,” Alemán said. “No windows, a lot of trash. We spent three years trying to get this building into shape so that the city would give us an occupancy certificate.”

For much of its 45 years, the center has been an economic engine for the area, contributing billions to the community, according to Alemán’s rudimentary figures over the years.

Alemán said laborers would come to school at night, pay weekly to afford the courses and participate in the center’s graduation ceremony. For some, that was the only graduation they’d ever had – and the center’s connections with nearby companies guaranteed a job for some, especially in HVAC or electrical careers.

“They’d go from making \$4, \$6 (an hour) to making in excess of \$20,” Alemán said. “They all made good money once they finished here.”

“That was our dream – to assist people that were trying to get something going that would help the community. Needless to say, we were providing places for people, but we didn’t have any money, and so we could barely make it on our own. And so we never had an opportunity to properly get this building in shape.” Z